

The Torma Ritual for the Relief of the Flaming-Mouthed Female Hungry Ghost

Toh 647 · Derge Kangyur

ཡིདགས་མཁོ་འབར་མ་དབུས་དབུ་བའ་གི་ཏེ་མའ་ཆེ་གོ

Toh 647 in the Kangyur is a ritual text known in English as "The Torma Ritual for the Relief of the Flaming-Mouthed Female Hungry Ghost," corresponding to the Tibetan title Yidakmo Khabarma Dbugs Dbyang Ba'i Gtor Ma'i Cho Ga. The text belongs to the dhāraṇī section of the Kangyur and takes the form of a ceremonial torma-offering rite designed to liberate hungry ghosts — beings tormented by insatiable craving — from their suffering, with particular focus on a preta known as Flaming Mouth whose agonized condition is revealed to the monk Ānanda. Set in the Nyagrodha Grove at Kapilavastu, the narrative frames the ritual instructions within a sūtra-style discourse in which the Buddha responds to Ānanda's encounter with this afflicted being. The text thus bridges doctrinal teaching on the preta realm with practical liturgical guidance for performing offerings on behalf of suffering spirits.

Here ends the dhāraṇī that provides refuge from blazing fire.

The Torma Ritual for the Relief of the Flaming-Mouthed Female Hungry Ghost.

Homage to the Three Jewels.

Then the Blessed One was dwelling in the land of Kapilavastu, in the Nyagrodha Grove's pleasure garden, together with a great assembly of monks, a great assembly of bodhisattvas, and a great multitude of sentient beings, and he was teaching the Dharma. At that time, Ānanda sat alone in a secluded place. Resting his mind within, settling inwardly and directing his attention one-pointedly, he was practicing the Dharma through direct perception. In the last part of the night, a female hungry ghost (preta) called Flaming Mouth appeared before him and said: "Alas, Ānanda, you shall die before long and will be reborn in the realm of hungry ghosts." Ānanda asked: "What means of support is there?" The female hungry ghost replied: "Ānanda, if tomorrow morning you give food and drink to as many hungry ghosts as there are grains of sand in ten million times one hundred thousand Ganges rivers, giving each and every hungry ghost seven large measures of food and drink such as are used in Magadha, and if you also satisfy a hundred thousand brahmin sages, and if offerings are made to the Three Jewels in my name, then your life too

will be prolonged, and I myself will pass away from the realm of hungry ghosts and be reborn in a higher world." Then Ānanda beheld the female hungry ghost Flaming Mouth: emaciated and of hideous complexion, her body withered, flames blazing from her mouth, her belly and throat parched with thirst, her matted hair dishevelled, her body hair and nails grown long. He heard her words, which were harsh and unpleasant, and was seized with fear and shock, his hair standing on end. He rose from his seat and, with great long strides and swift urgency, went directly to where the Blessed One was. Arriving there, he prostrated at the feet of the Blessed One and, still trembling, spoke these words: "Blessed One, please grant protection. Sugata, please grant protection. I, your servant, am to lose my life and die. Blessed One, I saw the female hungry ghost Flaming Mouth, and when she said to me, 'You shall die before long,' and I asked what means there were, she replied that if I were to satisfy as many hungry ghosts as there are grains of sand in ten million times one hundred thousand Ganges rivers, and also satisfy a hundred thousand brahmin sages, then my life would be prolonged. Blessed One, I pray you instruct me in how this is to be accomplished." Then the Blessed One, the Tathāgata Śākyamuni, spoke to the Venerable Ānanda these words: "Ānanda, there is a means by which you will be able to satisfy the hungry ghosts and the brahmin sages, so do not be afraid. Ānanda, there is a dhāraṇī called Sovereign Radiance, Powerful Light Pervading All Directions. By merely bestowing it, one will satisfy hungry ghosts as numerous as the grains of sand in ten million times one hundred thousand Ganges rivers, and each hungry ghost and each brahmin sage will receive seven measures of food and drink such as are used in Magadha. Indeed, in a former time, when I was a brahmin, I received this dhāraṇī from the great bodhisattva Lokeśvara and from the Tathāgata Lokeśvara Light. With it I satisfied countless and more-than-countless hungry ghosts and brahmin sages with food and drink, and all of them passed away from the realm of hungry ghosts and were reborn in the realm of the gods. Ānanda, receive this dhāraṇī and learn it by heart."

Namas sarva tathāgata avalokite. Oṃ sambhara sambhara hūṃ.

Ānanda, having recited this dhāraṇī seven times over the tormas offering for hungry ghosts, stretch out your hand and present it at the doorway. Strike the finger-cymbals as well. Having done so, the moment the offering is given, all the hungry ghosts of the four directions, as many as the grains of sand in a hundred thousand times ten million Ganges rivers, will be satisfied. Each individual hungry ghost will receive seven measures of food and drink such as

are used in Magadha. The mere act of eating it will cause them to pass away from the realm of hungry ghosts and be reborn among the gods.

Ānanda, you should always and without interruption spread this teaching to monks, nuns, laymen, and laywomen. Whoever does so will come to possess a great accumulation of merit, and their life will be long. They will come to possess an accumulation of merit equal to that of a hundred thousand times ten million Tathāgatas. They will constantly be unseen by wandering non-human spirits, flesh-eaters, vessel-spirits, yakṣas, rākṣasas, malevolent spirits, and hungry ghosts. They will be endowed with strength and with diligence. They will be endowed with a fine form, with splendor, and with mindfulness.

One who wishes to satisfy the brahmin sages should recite this dhāraṇī seven times over an offering vessel, over what is to be poured as a libation, and over a bowl filled to the brim, and then present them at whatever place flowing water is to be found. Having done so, the brahmin sages, as many as the grains of sand in countless hundreds of thousands of times ten millions of Ganges rivers, will be satisfied with divine food and drink. Those brahmin sages will have their senses satisfied, and every one of them will utter the sound of the syllable oṃ, exclaiming "May there be well-being and happiness!" Those beings will have their minds utterly purified, will come to be endowed with brahminical splendor, and will always live in celibacy. They will also come to be endowed with roots of virtue equal to the grains of sand in a hundred thousand times ten million Ganges rivers of Tathāgatas. All enemies will constantly be destroyed.

Recite the dhāraṇī twenty-one times over flowers, or incense, or perfume, or offerings of food and drink, and then present them to the Buddha, the Dharma, and the Saṅgha. Whoever does so — whether a son of good family, a daughter of good family, a monk, a nun, a layman, or a laywoman — will have made an offering to the Buddha, the Dharma, and the Saṅgha in the buddha-fields of all the Tathāgatas of the ten directions, with the highest of divine offerings and of Tathāgata offerings. It will be accounted as having made a painting, as having made a portrait. All Tathāgatas will regard them with favor and give them prophecies of awakening, and all the gods will constantly protect them.

Ānanda, go now and proclaim this. Teach it correctly and repeatedly to all sentient beings. Accumulate all collections of roots of virtue. This is what I declare.

Here ends the ritual of the tormā for the relief of hungry ghosts of the Flaming-Mouth.

Translator's Notes

- The expression rendered "ten million times one hundred thousand" reflects the Tibetan "bye ba khrag khrig phrag 'bum," a stacking of large numerical units: bye ba is ten million, khrag khrig is one hundred billion, and phrag 'bum is one hundred thousand; in context this is a conventional hyperbolic figure for an incomprehensibly vast number, here applied to grains of sand in Ganges rivers. The rendering above follows the literal sequence as best as readable English allows.

The two buddha-names "Lokeśvara" and "Tathāgata Lokeśvara Light" render the Tibetan "'jig rten dbang phyug" and "de bzhin gshegs pa 'jig rten dbang phyug 'od" respectively. The first is treated as the bodhisattva Avalokiteśvara in some recensions, but the Tibetan here explicitly distinguishes a bodhisattva figure from a Tathāgata of the same root name, suggesting two distinct figures from the canonical source of this dhāraṇī; this textual distinction is preserved without harmonizing.

- The phrase rendered "vessel-spirits" translates a term that appears to be a list of supernatural beings; the specific term here is somewhat opaque and may refer to a class of spirits associated with water-vessels or ritual jars. The rendering is provisional.

The phrase "made a painting, made a portrait" translates two verbs that suggest the offering is as meritorious as commissioning an image or painted likeness of a buddha — a standard formula of comparison in this genre of text.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.